▼ GLASSHOUSE



CHOPPER TROUBLES

The incessant rains are triggering landslides across Kerala and some of the muck is falling on chief minister **V.D. Satheesan** too. The Opposition CPI(M) has accused the veteran Congressman of "extravagance", for allegedly using a state-leased helicopter on August 1 to visit his ailing father-in-law in Kochi. Also doing the rounds are pictures of him enjoying a sumptuous meal at a political leader's house in Ponnani... not good optics when some 11,000 people are struggling in flood relief camps all over the state. Satheesan has been aggressive in his response, saying the chopper flight was to meet foreign investors who were on a deadline (he refused to name who they were). As for the lunch date, he asked whether there was a rule that a CM should "stop eating food" because there was a crisis. The controversy has also revived Satheesan's earlier criticism, as Opposition leader, of the Left Front regime's Rs 80 lakh a month helicopter lease, which he had called extravagant then. Incidentally, as of August 2, the CM had yet to visit the flood-hit areas.

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ SEVEN YEARS OF ANANDIBEN

LASTING STINT

Anandiben Patel is now Uttar Pradesh's longest-serving governor, surpassing Sir Maurice Garnier Hallett, who served for six years when the region was known as the United Provinces (1939-45). Patel, 84, is also the second woman to hold the post in the state after Sarojini Naidu. Since taking office in 2019 (she completed seven years in office on July 29), she has



frequently drawn attention for speaking on social issues, including crimes against women, live-in relationships and the serving of non-vegetarian food in medical institutions. A former school principal, she was also Gujarat's first woman CM. Political observers link her unusually long tenure to the BJP's OBC outreach and social engineering strategy in UP. Patel is widely expected to remain in office till the 2027 assembly election, further extending her record streak.